

Cyclops

ΕΥΡΙΠΙΔΟΥ ΚΥΚΛΩΨ

Euripides

translated by E. P. Coleridge (1891)

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1

Scene. — Mount Aetna in Sicily, before the cave of the Cyclops.

SILENUS: O Bromius, unnumbered are the toils I bear because of thee, no less now than when I was young and hale; first, when thou wert driven mad by Hera and didst leave the mountain nymphs, thy nurses; next, when in battle with earth-born spearmen I stood beside thee on the right as squire, and slew Enceladus, smiting him full in the middle of his targe with my spear. Come, though, let me see; must I confess 'twas all a dream? No, by Zeus! since I really showed his spoils to the Bacchic god. And now am I enduring to the full a toil still worse than those. For when Hera sent forth a race of Tyrrhene pirates against thee, that thou mightest be smuggled far away, I, as soon as the news reached me, sailed in quest of thee with my children; and, taking the helm myself, I stood on the end of the stern and steered our trim craft; and my sons, sitting at the oars, made the grey billows froth and foam as they sought thee, my liege. But just as we had come nigh Malea in our course, an east-wind blew upon the ship and drove us hither to the rock of Aetna, where in lonely caverns dwell the one-eyed children of ocean's god, the murdering Cyclopes. Captured by one of them we are slaves in his house; Polyphemus they call him whom we serve; and instead of Bacchic revelry we are herding a godless Cyclops's flocks; and so it is my children, striplings as they are, tend the young thereof on the edge of the downs; while my appointed task is to stay here and fill the troughs and sweep out the cave, or wait upon the ungodly Cyclops at his impious feasts. His orders now compel obedience; I have to scrape out his house with the rake you see, so as to receive the Cyclops, my absent master, and his sheep in clean caverns. But already I see my children driving their browsing flocks towards me. What means this? is the beat of feet in the Sicinnis dance the same to you now as when ye attended the Bacchic god in his revelries and made

your way with dainty steps to the music of lyres to the halls of Althaea?

41

CHORUS: Offspring of well-bred sires and dams, pray whither wilt thou be gone from me to the rocks? Hast thou not here a gentle breeze, and grass to browse, and water from the eddying stream set near the cave in troughs? and are not thy young ones bleating for thee?

49

CHORUS: Pst! pst! wilt thou not browse here, here on the dewy slope? Ho? ho! ere long will I cast a stone at thee. Away, away! O horned one, to the fold-keeper of the Cyclops, the country-ranging shepherd.

55

CHORUS: Loosen thy bursting udder; welcome to thy teats the kids, whom thou leavest in the lambkins' pens. Those little bleating kids, asleep the livelong day, miss thee; wilt then leave at last the rich grass pastures on the peaks of Aetna and enter the fold?

62a

CHORUS: ...

63

CHORUS: Here we have no Bromian god; no dances here, or Bacchantes thyrsus-bearing; no roll of drums, or drops of sparkling wine by gurgling founts; nor is it now with Nymphs in Nysa I sing a song of Bacchus, Bacchus! to the queen of love, in quest of whom I once sped on with Bacchantes, white of foot. Dear friend, dear Bacchic god, whither art roaming alone, waving thy auburn locks, while I, thy minister, do service to the one-eyed Cyclops, a slave and wanderer I, clad in this wretched goat-skin dress, severed from thy love?

82

SILENUS: Hush, children! and bid our servants fold the flocks in the rock-roofed cavern.

84

CHORUS: (*To Servants.*) Away! (*To Silenus.*) But prithee, why such haste, father?

85

SILENUS: I see the hull of a ship from Hellas at the shore, and men, that wield the oar, on their way to this cave with some chieftain. About their necks they carry empty vessels and pitchers for water; they are in want of food. Luckless strangers! who can they be? They know not what manner of man our master Polyphemus is, to have set foot here in his cheerless abode and come to the jaws of the cannibal Cyclops in an evil hour. But hold ye your peace, that we may inquire whence they come to the peak of Sicilian Aetna.

96

ODYSSEUS: Pray tell us, sirs, of some river-spring whence we might draw a draught to slake our thirst, or of someone willing to sell victuals to mariners in need. Why, what is this? We seem to have chanced upon a city of the Bromian god; here by the caves I see a group of Satyrs. To the eldest first I bid "All hail!"

102

SILENUS: All hail, sir! tell me who thou art, and name thy country.

103

ODYSSEUS: Odysseus of Ithaca, king of the Cephalenians' land.

104

SILENUS: I know him for a prating knave, one of Sisyphus' shrewd offspring.

105

ODYSSEUS: I am the man; abuse me not.

106

SILENUS: Whence hast thou sailed hither to Sicily?

107

ODYSSEUS: From Ilium and the toils of Troy.

108

SILENUS: How was that? didst thou not know the passage to thy native land?

109

ODYSSEUS: Tempestuous winds drove me hither against my will.

110

SILENUS: God wot! thou art in the same plight as I am.

111

ODYSSEUS: Why, wert thou too drifted hither against thy will?

112

SILENUS: I was, as I pursued the pirates who carried Bromius off.

113

ODYSSEUS: What land is this and who are its inhabitants?

114

SILENUS: This is mount Aetna, the highest point in Sicily.

115

ODYSSEUS: But where are the city-walls and ramparts?

116

SILENUS: There are none; the headlands, sir, are void of men.

117

ODYSSEUS: Who then possess the land? the race of wild creatures?

118

SILENUS: The Cyclopes, who have caves, not roofed houses.

119

ODYSSEUS: Obedient unto whom? or is the power in the people's hands?

120

SILENUS: They are rovers; no man obeys another in anything.

121

ODYSSEUS: Do they sow Demeter's grain, or on what do they live?

122

SILENUS: On milk and cheese and flesh of sheep.

123

ODYSSEUS: Have they the drink of Bromius, the juice of the vine?

124

SILENUS: No indeed! and thus it is a joyless land they dwell in.

125

ODYSSEUS: Are they hospitable and reverent towards strangers?

126

SILENUS: Strangers, they say, supply the daintiest meat.

127

ODYSSEUS: What, do they delight in killing men and eating them?

128

SILENUS: No one has ever arrived here without being butchered.

129

ODYSSEUS: Where is the Cyclops himself? inside his dwelling?

130

SILENUS: He is gone hunting wild beasts with hounds on Aetna.

131

ODYSSEUS: Dost know then what to do, that we may be gone from the land?

132

SILENUS: Not I, Odysseus; but I would do anything for thee.

133

ODYSSEUS: Sell us food, of which we are in need.

134

SILENUS: There is nothing but flesh, as I said.

135

ODYSSEUS: Well, even that is a pleasant preventive of hunger.

136

SILENUS: And there is cheese curdled with fig-juice, and the milk of kine.

137

ODYSSEUS: Bring them out; a man should see his purchases.

138

SILENUS: But tell me, how much gold wilt thou give me in exchange?

139

ODYSSEUS: No gold bring I, but Dionysus' drink.

140

SILENUS: Most welcome words! I have long been wanting that.

141

ODYSSEUS: Yes, it was Maron, the god's son, who gave me a draught.

142

SILENUS: What! Maron whom once I dandled in these arms?

143

ODYSSEUS: The son of the Bacchic god, that thou mayst learn more certainly.

144

SILENUS: Is it inside the ship, or hast thou it with thee?

145

ODYSSEUS: This, as thou seest, is the skin that holds it, old sir.

146

SILENUS: Why, that would not give me so much as a mouthful.

147

ODYSSEUS: This, and twice as much again as will run from the skin.

148

SILENUS: Fair the rill thou speakest of, delicious to me.

149

ODYSSEUS: Shall I let thee taste the wine unmixed, to start with?

150

SILENUS: A reasonable offer; for of a truth a taste invites the purchase.

151

ODYSSEUS: Well, I haul about a cup as well as the skin.

152

SILENUS: Come, let it gurgle in, that I may revive my memory by a pull at it.

153

ODYSSEUS: There then!

153b

SILENUS: Ye gods! what a delicious scent it has!

154

ODYSSEUS: What! didst thou see it?

154b

SILENUS: No, i' faith, but I smell it.

155

ODYSSEUS: Taste it then, that thy approval may not stop at words.

156

SILENUS: Zounds! Bacchus is inviting me to dance; ha! ha!

158

ODYSSEUS: Did it not gurgle finely down thy throttle?

159

SILENUS: Aye that it did, to the ends of my fingers.

160

ODYSSEUS: Well, we will give thee money besides.

161

SILENUS: Only undo the skin, and never mind the money.

162

ODYSSEUS: Bring out the cheeses then and lambs.

163

SILENUS: I will do so, with small thought of any master. For let me have a single cup of that and I would turn madman, giving in exchange for it the flocks of every Cyclops and then throwing myself into the sea from the Leucadian rock, once I have been well drunk and smoothed out my wrinkled brow. For if a man rejoice not in his drinking, he is mad; for in drinking there is love with all its frolic, and dancing withal, and oblivion of woe. Shall not I then purchase so rare a drink, bidding the senseless Cyclops and his central eye go hang?

170

Exit Silenus.

175

CHORUS: Hearken, Odysseus, let us hold some converse with thee.

176

ODYSSEUS: Well, do so; ours is a meeting of friends.

177

CHORUS: Did you take Troy and capture the famous Helen?

178

ODYSSEUS: Aye, and we destroyed the whole family of Priam.

179

CHORUS: After capturing your blooming prize, were all of you in turn her lovers? for she likes variety in husbands; the traitress! the sight of a man with embroidered breeches on his legs and a golden chain about his neck so fluttered her, that she left Menelaus, her excellent little husband. Would there had never been a race of women born into the world at all, unless it were for me alone!

188

SILENUS: (*reappearing with food.*) Lo! I bring you fat food from the flocks, king Odysseus, the young of bleating sheep and cheeses of curdled milk without stint. Carry them away with you and be gone from the cave at once, after giving me a drink of merry grape-juice in exchange.

193

CHORUS: Alack! yonder comes the Cyclops; what shall we do?

194

ODYSSEUS: Then truly are we lost, old sir! whither must we fly?

195

SILENUS: Inside this rock, for there ye may conceal yourselves.

196

ODYSSEUS: Dangerous advice of thine, to run into the net!

197

SILENUS: No danger; there are ways of escape in plenty in the rock.

198

ODYSSEUS: No, never that; for surely Troy will groan and loudly too, if we flee from a single man, when I have oft withstood with my shield a countless host of Phrygians. Nay, if die we must, we will die a noble death; or, if we live, we will maintain our old renown at least with credit.

203

CYCLOPS: A light here! hold it up! what is this? what means this idleness, your Bacchic revelry? Here have we no Dionysus, nor clash of brass, nor roll of drums. Pray, how is it with my newly-born lambs in the caves? are they at the teat, running close to the side of their dams? Is the full amount of milk for cheeses milked out in baskets of rushes? How now? what say you? One of ye will soon be shedding tears from the weight of my club; look up, not down.

212

CHORUS: There! my head is bent back till I see Zeus himself; I behold both the stars and Orion.

214

CYCLOPS: Is my breakfast quite ready?

215

CHORUS: 'Tis laid; be thy throat only ready.

216

CYCLOPS: Are the bowls too full of milk?

217

CHORUS: Aye, so that thou canst swill off a whole hogshead, so it please thee.

218

CYCLOPS: Sheep's milk or cows' milk or a mixture of both?

219

CHORUS: Whichever thou wilt; don't swallow me, that's all.

220

CYCLOPS: Not I; for you would start kicking in the pit of my stomach and kill me by your antics. (*Catching sight of Odysseus and his followers.*) Ha! what is this crowd I see near the folds? Some pirates or robbers have put in here. Yes, I really see the lambs from my caves tied up there with twisted osiers, cheese-presses scattered about, and old Silenus with his bald pate all swollen with blows.

228

SILENUS: Oh! oh! poor wretch that I am, pounded to a fever.

229

CYCLOPS: By whom? who has been pounding thy head, old sirrah?

230

SILENUS: These are the culprits, Cyclops, all because I refused to let them plunder thee.

231

CYCLOPS: Did they not know I was a god and sprung from gods?

232

SILENUS: That was what I told them, but they persisted in plundering thy goods, and, in spite of my efforts, they actually began to eat the cheese and carry off the lambs; and they said they would tie thee in a three-cubit pillory and tear out thy bowels by force at thy navel, and flay thy back thoroughly with the scourge; and then, after binding thee, fling thy carcase down among the benches of their ship to sell to some one for heaving up stones, or else throw thee into a mill.

241

CYCLOPS: Oh, indeed! Be off then and sharpen my cleavers at once; heap high the faggots and light them; for they shall be slain forthwith and fill this maw of mine, what time I pick my feast hot from the coals, waiting not for carvers, and fish up the rest from the cauldron boiled and sodden; for I have had my fill of mountain-fare and sated myself with banquets of lions and stags, but 'tis long I have been without human flesh.

250

SILENUS: Truly, master, a change like this is all the sweeter after everyday fare; for just of late there have been no fresh arrivals of strangers at these caves.

253

ODYSSEUS: Hear the strangers too in turn, Cyclops. We had come near the cave from our ship, wishing to procure provisions by purchase, when this fellow sold us the lambs and handed them over for a stoup of wine to drink himself,—a voluntary act on both sides,—there was no violence employed at all. No, there is not a particle of truth in the story he tells, now that he has been caught selling thy property behind thy back.

261

SILENUS: I? Perdition catch thee!

261b

ODYSSEUS: If I am lying, yes.

262

SILENUS: O Cyclops, by thy sire Poseidon, by mighty Triton and Nereus, by Calypso and the daughters of Nereus, by the sacred billows and all the race of fishes! I swear to thee, most noble sir, dear little Cyclops, master mine, it is not I who sell thy goods to strangers, else may these children, dearly as I love them, come to an evil end.

270

CHORUS: Keep that for thyself; with my own eyes I saw thee sell the goods to the strangers; and if I lie, perdition catch my sire! but injure not the strangers.

273

CYCLOPS: Ye lie; for my part I put more faith in him than Rhadamanthus, declaring him more just. But I have some questions to ask. Whence sailed ye, strangers? of what country are you? what city was it nursed your childhood?

277

ODYSSEUS: We are Ithacans by birth, and have been driven from our course by the winds of the sea on our way from Ilium, after sacking its citadel.

280

CYCLOPS: Are ye the men who visited on Ilium, that bordereth on Scamander's wave, the rape of Helen, worst of women?

282

ODYSSEUS: We are; that was the fearful labour we endured.

283

CYCLOPS: A sorry expedition yours, to have sailed to the land of Phrygia for the sake of one woman!

285

ODYSSEUS: It was a god's doing; blame not any son of man. But thee do we implore, most noble son of Ocean's god, speaking as free-born men; be not so cruel as to slay thy friends on their coming to thy cave, nor regard us as food for thy jaws, an impious meal; for we preserved thy sire, O king, in possession of his temple-seats deep in the nooks of Hellas; and the sacred port of Taenarus and Malea's furthest coves remain unharmed; and Sunium's rock, the silver-veined, sacred to Zeus-born Athena, still is safe, and Geraestus, the harbour of refuge; and we did not permit Phrygians to put such an intolerable reproach on Hellas.¹ Now in these things thou too hast a share, for thou dwellest in a corner of the land of Hellas beneath Aetna's fire-streaming rock; and although thou turn from arguments, still it is a custom amongst mortal men to receive shipwrecked sailors as their suppliants and show them hospitality and help them with raiment; not that these should fill thy jaws and belly, their limbs transfix'd with spits for piercing ox-flesh. The land of Priam hath emptied Hellas quite enough, drinking the blood of many whom the spear laid low, with the ruin it has brought on widowed wives, on aged childless dames, and hoary-headed sires; and if thou roast and consume the remnant,—a meal thou wilt rue,—why, where shall one turn? Nay, be persuaded by me, Cyclops; forego thy ravenous greed and choose piety rather than

wickedness; for on many a man ere now unrighteous gains have brought down retribution.

313

SILENUS: ... I will give thee a word of advice! as for his flesh, leave not a morsel of it, and if thou eat his tongue, Cyclops, thou wilt become a monstrous clever talker.

316

CYCLOPS: Wealth, manikin, is the god for the wise; all else is mere vaunting and fine words. Plague take the headlands by the sea, on which my father seats himself! Why hast thou put forward these arguments? I shudder not at Zeus's thunder, nor know I wherein Zeus is a mightier god than I, sir stranger; what is more, I reckon not of him; my reasons hear. When he pours down the rain from above, here in this rock in quarters snug, feasting on roast calf's flesh or some wild game and moistening well my upturned paunch with deep draughts from a tub of milk, I rival the thunderclaps of Zeus with my artillery; and when the north-wind blows from Thrace and sheddeth snow, I wrap my carcase in the hides of beasts and light a fire, and what care I for snow? The earth perforce, whether she like it or not, produces grass and fattens my flocks, which I sacrifice to no one save myself and this belly, the greatest of deities; but to the gods, not I! For surely to eat and drink one's fill from day to day and give oneself no grief at all, this is the king of gods for your wise man, but lawgivers go hang, chequering, as they do, the life of man! And so I will not cease from indulging myself by devouring thee; and thou shalt receive this stranger's gift, that I may be free of blame,—fire and my father's element yonder, and a cauldron to hold thy flesh and boil it nicely in collops. So in with you, that ye may feast me well, standing round the altar to honour the cavern's god.

345

Enters his cave.

347

ODYSSEUS: Alas! escaped from the troubles of Troy and the sea, my barque now strands upon the whim and forbidding heart of this savage. O Pallas, mistress mine, goddess-daughter of Zeus, help me, help me now; for I am come to toils and depths of peril worse than all at Ilium; and thou, O Zeus, the stranger's god, who hast thy dwelling 'mid the radiant stars, behold these things; for, if thou regard them not, in vain art thou esteemed the great god Zeus, though but a thing of naught.

355

Follows the Cyclops reluctantly.

356

CHORUS: Ope wide the portal of thy gaping throat, Cyclops; for strangers' limbs, both boiled and grilled, are ready from off the coals for thee to gnaw and tear and mince up small, reclining in thy shaggy goatskin coat.

361

CHORUS: Relinquish not thy meal for me; keep that boat for thyself alone.² Avaunt this cave! avaunt the burnt-offerings, which the godless Cyclops offers on Aetna's altars, exulting in meals on strangers' flesh!

369

CHORUS: Oh! the ruthless monster! to sacrifice his guests at his own hearth, the suppliants of his halls, cleaving and tearing and serving up to his loathsome teeth a feast of human flesh, hot from the coals.

374b

CHORUS: ...

375

ODYSSEUS: (*reappearing with a look of horror.*) O Zeus! what can I say after the hideous sights I have seen inside the cave, things past belief, resembling more the tales men tell than aught they do?

377

CHORUS: What news, Odysseus? has the Cyclops, most godless monster, been feasting on thy dear comrades?

379

ODYSSEUS: Aye, he singled out a pair, on whom the flesh was fattest and in best condition, and took them up in his hand to weigh.

381

CHORUS: How went it with you then, poor wretch?

382

ODYSSEUS: When we had entered yonder rocky abode, he lighted first a fire, throwing logs of towering oak upon his spacious hearth, enough for three waggons to carry as their load; next, close by the blazing flame, he placed his couch of pine-boughs laid upon the floor, and filled a bowl of some ten firkins, pouring white milk thereinto, after he had milked his kine; and by his side he put a can of ivy-wood, whose breadth was three cubits and its depth four maybe; [next he set his brazen pot a-boiling on the fire,]³ spits too he set beside him, fashioned of the branches of thorn, their points hardened in the fire and the rest of them trimmed with the hatchet, and the blood-bowls of Aetna for the axe's edge.⁴ Now when that hell-cook, god-detested, had everything quite ready, he caught up a pair of my companions and proceeded deliberately to cut the throat of one of them over the yawning brazen pot; but the other he clutched by the tendon of his heel, and, striking him against a sharp point of rocky stone, dashed out his brains; then, after hacking the fleshy parts with glutton cleaver, he set to grilling them, but the limbs he threw into his cauldron to seethe. And I, poor wretch, drew near with streaming eyes and waited on the Cyclops; but the others kept cowering like frightened birds in crannies of the rock, and the blood forsook their skin. Anon, when he had gorged himself upon my comrades' flesh and had fallen on his back, breathing heavily, there came a sudden inspiration to me. I filled a cup of this Maronian wine and offered him a draught, saying, "Cyclops, son of Ocean's god, see here what heavenly drink the grapes of Hellas yield, glad gift of Dionysus." He,

glutted with his shameless meal, took and drained it at one draught, and, lifting up his hand, he thanked me thus, "Dearest to me of all my guests! fair the drink thou givest me to crown so fair a feast." Now when I saw his delight, I gave him another cup, knowing the wine would make him rue it, and he would soon be paying the penalty. Then he set to singing; but I kept filling bumper after bumper and heating him with drink. So there he is singing discordantly amid the weeping of my fellow-sailors, and the cave re-echoes; but I have made my way out quietly and would fain save thee and myself, if thou wilt. Tell me then, is it your wish, or is it not, to fly from this unsocial wretch and take up your abode with Naiad nymphs in the halls of the Bacchic god? Thy father within approves this scheme; but there! he is powerless, getting all he can out of his liquor; his wings are snared by the cup as if he had flown against bird-lime, and he is fuddled; but thou art young and lusty; so save thyself with my help and regain thy old friend Dionysus, so little like the Cyclops.

437

CHORUS: Best of friends, would we might see that day, escaping the godless Cyclops! [for 'tis long we have been without the joys of men, unable to escape him.]⁵

441

ODYSSEUS: Hear then how I will requite this vile monster and rescue you from thraldom.

443

CHORUS: Tell me how; no note of Asiatic lyre would sound more sweetly in our ears than news of the Cyclops' death.

445

ODYSSEUS: Delighted with this liquor of the Bacchic god, he fain would go a-revelling with his brethren.

447

CHORUS: I understand; thy purpose is to seize and slay him in the thickets when alone, or push him down a precipice.

449

ODYSSEUS: Not at all; my plan is fraught with subtlety.

450

CHORUS: What then? Truly we have long heard of thy cleverness.

451

ODYSSEUS: I mean to keep him from this revel, saying he must not give this drink to his brethren but keep it for himself alone and lead a happy life. Then when he falls asleep, o'ermastered by the Bacchic god, I will put a point with this sword of mine to an olive-branch I saw lying in the cave, and will set it on fire; and when I see it well alight, I will lift the heated brand, and, thrusting it full in the Cyclops' eye, melt out his sight with its blaze; and, as when a man in fitting the timbers of a ship makes his auger spin to and fro with a double strap, so will I make the brand revolve in the eye that gives the Cyclops light and will scorch up the pupil thereof.

464

CHORUS: Ho! ho! how glad I feel! wild with joy at the contrivance!

466

ODYSSEUS: That done, I will embark thee and those thou lovest with old Silenus in the deep hold of my black ship, my ship with double banks of oars, and carry you away from this land.

469

CHORUS: Well, can I too lay hold of the blinding brand, as though the god's libation had been poured? for I would fain have a share in this offering of blood.

472

ODYSSEUS: Indeed thou must, for the brand is large, and thou must help hold it.

473

CHORUS: How lightly would I lift the load of e'en a hundred wains, if that will help us to grub out the eye of the doomed Cyclops, like a wasp's nest.

476

ODYSSEUS: Hush! for now thou knowest my plot in full, and when I bid you, obey the author of it; for I am not the man to desert my friends inside the cave and save myself alone. And yet I might escape; I am clear of the cavern's depths already; but no! to desert the friends with whom I journeyed hither and only save myself is not a righteous course.

480

Re-enters the cave.

483

FIRST HALF-CHORUS: Come, who will be the first and who the next to him upon the list to grip the handle of the brand, and, thrusting it into the Cyclops' eye, gouge out the light thereof?

487

SECOND HALF-CHORUS: Hush! hush! Behold the drunkard leaves his rocky home, trolling loud some hideous lay, a clumsy tuneless clown, whom tears await. Come, let us give this boor a lesson in revelry. Ere long will he be blind at any rate.

495

FIRST HALF-CHORUS: Happy he who plays the Bacchanal amid the precious streams distilled from grapes, stretched at full length for a revel, his arm around the friend he loves, and some fair dainty damsel on his couch, his hair perfumed with nard and glossy, the while he calls, "Oh! who will ope the door for me?"

503

CYCLOPS: Ha! ha! full of wine and merry with the feast's good cheer⁶ am I, my hold freighted like a merchant-ship up to my belly's very top. This turf graciously invites me to seek my brother Cyclopes for a revel in the spring-tide. Come, stranger, bring the wine-skin hither and hand it over to me.

511

SECOND HALF-CHORUS: Forth from the house its fair lord comes, casting his fair glance round him. We have some one to befriend us.⁷ A hostile brand is awaiting thee, no tender bride in dewy grot. No single

colour will those garlands have, that soon shall cling so close about thy brow.

519

ODYSSEUS: (*Returning with the wineskin.*) Hearken, Cyclops; for I am well versed in the ways of Bacchus, whom I have given thee to drink.

521

CYCLOPS: And who is Bacchus? some reputed god?

522

ODYSSEUS: The greatest god men know to cheer their life.

523

CYCLOPS: I like his after-taste at any rate.

524

ODYSSEUS: This is the kind of god he is; he harmeth no man.

525

CYCLOPS: But how does a god like being housed in a wine-skin?

526

ODYSSEUS: Put him where one may, he is content there.

527

CYCLOPS: It is not right that gods should be clad in leather.

528

ODYSSEUS: What of that, provided he please thee? does the leather hurt thee?

529

CYCLOPS: I hate the wine-skin, but the liquor we have here I love.

530

ODYSSEUS: Stay, then, Cyclops; drink and be merry.

531

CYCLOPS: Must I not give my brethren a share in this liquor?

532

ODYSSEUS: No, keep it thyself and thou wilt appear of more honour.

533

CYCLOPS: Give it my friends and I shall appear of more use.

534

ODYSSEUS: Revelling is apt to end in blows, abuse, and strife.

535

CYCLOPS: I may be drunk, but no man will lay hands on me for all that.

536

ODYSSEUS: Better stay at home, my friend, after a carouse.

537

CYCLOPS: Who loves not revelling then is but a simpleton.

538

ODYSSEUS: But whoso stays at home, when drunk, is wise.

539

CYCLOPS: What shall we do, Silenus? art minded to stay?

540

SILENUS: That I am; for what need have we of others to share our drink, Cyclops?

541

CYCLOPS: Well, truly the turf is soft as down with its fresh flowering plants.

542

SILENUS: (*seating himself.*) Aye, and 'tis pleasant drinking in the warm sunshine.

542a

CYCLOPS: ...⁸

543

SILENUS: Come, let me see thee stretch thy carcase on the ground.

544

CYCLOPS: (*sitting down.*) [There then!] Why art thou putting the mixing-bowl behind me?

546

SILENUS: That no one passing by may come upon it.⁹

546b

CYCLOPS: Nay, but thy purpose is to drink upon the sly; set it between us. (*To Odysseus.*) Now tell me, stranger, by what name to call thee.

549

ODYSSEUS: Noman. What boon shall I receive of thee to earn my thanks?

550

CYCLOPS: I will feast on thee last, after all thy comrades.

551

ODYSSEUS: Fair indeed the honour thou bestowest on thy guest, sir Cyclops!

552

CYCLOPS: (*turning suddenly to Silenus.*) Ho, sirrah! what art thou about? taking a stealthy pull at the wine?

553

SILENUS: No, but it kissed me for my good looks.

554

CYCLOPS: Thou shalt smart, if thou kiss the wine when it kisses not thee.

555

SILENUS: Oh! but it did, for it says it is in love with my handsome face.

556

CYCLOPS: (*holding out his cup.*) Pour in; only give me my cup full.

557

SILENUS: H'm! how is it mixed? just let me make sure.

Takes another pull.

558

CYCLOPS: Perdition! give it me at once.

558b

SILENUS: Oh, no! I really cannot, till I see thee with a crown on, and have another taste myself.

560

CYCLOPS: My cup-bearer is a cheat.

560b

SILENUS: No really, but the wine is so luscious. Thou must wipe thy lips, though, to get a draught.

562

CYCLOPS: There! my lips and beard are clean now.

563

SILENUS: Bend thine elbow gracefully, and then quaff thy cup, as thou seest me do, and as now thou seest me not.

Burying his face in his cup.

565

CYCLOPS: Aha! what next?

565b

SILENUS: I drank it off at a draught with much pleasure.

566

CYCLOPS: Stranger, take the skin thyself and be my cup-bearer.

567

ODYSSEUS: Well, at any rate the grape is no stranger to my hand.

568

CYCLOPS: Come, pour it in.

568b

ODYSSEUS: In it goes! keep silence, that is all.

569

CYCLOPS: A difficult task when a man is deep in his cups.

570

ODYSSEUS: Here, take and drink it off; leave none.

570a

CYCLOPS: ...¹⁰

571

ODYSSEUS: Thou must be silent¹¹ and only give in when the liquor does.

572

CYCLOPS: God wot! it is a clever stock that bears the grape.

573

ODYSSEUS: Aye, and if thou but swallow plenty of it after a plentiful meal, moistening thy belly till its thirst is gone, it will throw thee into slumber; but if thou leave aught behind, the Bacchic god will parch thee for it.

576

CYCLOPS: Ha! ha! what a trouble it was getting out! This is pleasure unalloyed; earth and sky seem whirling round together; I see the throne of Zeus and all the godhead's majesty. Kiss *thee*! no! There are the Graces trying to tempt me. I shall rest well enough with my Ganymede here; yea, by the Graces, right fairly.

585

SILENUS: What! Cyclops, am I Ganymede, Zeus's minion?

586

CYCLOPS: (*attempting to carry him into the cave.*) To be sure, Ganymede whom I am carrying off from the halls of Dardanus.

587

SILENUS: I am undone, my children; outrageous treatment waits me.

588

CHORUS: Dost find fault with thy lover? dost scorn him in his cups?

589

SILENUS: Woe is me! most bitter shall I find the wine ere long.

Exit Silenus, dragged away by Cyclops.

590

ODYSSEUS: Up now, children of Dionysus, sons of a noble sire, soon will yon creature in the cave, relaxed in slumber as ye see him, spew from his shameless maw the meat. Already the brand inside his lair is vomiting a cloud of smoke; and the only reason we prepared it was to burn the Cyclops' eye; so mind thou quit thee like a man.

596

CHORUS: I will have a spirit as of rock or adamant; but go inside, before my father suffers any shameful treatment; for here thou hast things ready.

599

ODYSSEUS: O Hephaestus, lord of Aetna, rid thyself for once and all of a troublesome neighbour by burning his bright eye out. Come, Sleep, as well, offspring of sable Night, come with all thy power on the monster god-detested; and never after Troy's most glorious toils destroy Odysseus and his crew by the hands of one who recketh naught of God or man; else must we reckon Chance a goddess, and Heaven's will inferior to hers.

605

Odysseus re-enters the cave.

608

CHORUS: Tightly the pincers shall grip the neck of him who feasts upon his guest; for soon will he lose the light of his eye by fire; already the brand, a tree's huge limb, lurks amid the embers charred. Oh! come ye then and work his doom, pluck out the maddened Cyclops' eye, that he may rue his drinking. And I too fain would leave the Cyclops' lonely land and see king Bromius, ivy-crowned, the god I sorely miss. Ah! shall I ever come to that?

624

ODYSSEUS: (*leaving the cave cautiously.*) Silence, ye cattle! I adjure you; close your lips; make not a sound! I'll not let a man of you so much as breathe or wink or clear his throat, that yon pest awake not, until the sight in the Cyclops' eye has passed through the fiery ordeal.

629

CHORUS: Silent we stand with 'bated breath.

630

ODYSSEUS: In then, and mind your fingers grip the brand, for it is splendidly red-hot.

632

CHORUS: Thyself ordain who first must seize the blazing bar and burn the Cyclops' eye out, that we may share alike whate'er betides.

635

FIRST HALF-CHORUS: Standing where I am before the door, I am too far off to thrust the fire into his eye.

637

SECOND HALF-CHORUS: I have just gone lame.

638

FIRST HALF-CHORUS: Why, then, thou art in the same plight as I; for somehow or other I sprained my ankle, standing still.

640

ODYSSEUS: Sprained thy ankle, standing still?

640b

SECOND HALF-CHORUS: Yes, and my eyes are full of dust or ashes from somewhere or other.

642

ODYSSEUS: These are sorry fellows, worthless as allies.

643

CHORUS: Because I feel for my back and spine, and express no wish to have my teeth knocked out, I am a coward, am I? Well, but I know a spell of Orpheus, a most excellent one, to make the brand enter his skull of its own accord, and set alight the one-eyed son of Earth.

649

ODYSSEUS: Long since I knew thou wert by nature such an one, and now I know it better; I must employ my own friends; but, though thou bring no active aid, cheer us on at any rate, that I may find my friends emboldened by thy encouragement.

650

Exit Odysseus.

654

CHORUS: That will I do; the Carian¹² shall run the risk for us; and as far as encouragement goes, let the Cyclops smoulder.

656

CHORUS: What ho! my gallants, thrust away, make haste and burn his eye-brow off, the monster's guest-devouring. Oh! singe and scorch the shepherd of Aetna; twirl the brand and drag it round and be careful lest in his agony he treat thee to some wantonness.

663

CYCLOPS: (*Bellowing in the cave.*) Oh! oh! my once bright eye is burnt to cinders now.

664

CHORUS: Sweet indeed the triumph-song; pray sing it to us, Cyclops.

665

CYCLOPS: (*from within.*) Oh! oh! once more; what outrage on me and what ruin! But never shall ye escape this rocky cave unpunished, ye worthless creatures; for I will stand in the entrance of the cleft and fit my hands into it thus.

Staggering to the entrance.

669

CHORUS: Why dost thou cry out, Cyclops?

669b

CYCLOPS: I am undone.

670

CHORUS: Thou art indeed a sorry sight.

670b

CYCLOPS: Aye, and a sad one, too.

671

CHORUS: Didst fall among the coals in a drunken fit?

672

CYCLOPS: Noman has undone me.

672b

CHORUS: Then there is no one hurting thee after all.

673

CYCLOPS: Noman is blinding me.

673b

CHORUS: Then art thou not blind.

674

CYCLOPS: As blind as thou, forsooth.¹³

674b

CHORUS: How, pray, could no man have made thee blind?

675

CYCLOPS: Thou mockest me; but where is this Noman.

675b

CHORUS: Nowhere, Cyclops.

676

CYCLOPS: It was the stranger, vile wretch! who proved my ruin, that thou mayst understand rightly, by swilling me with the liquor he gave me.

678

CHORUS: Ah! wine is a terrible foe, hard to wrestle with.

679

CYCLOPS: Tell me, I adjure thee, have they escaped or are they still within?

680

CHORUS: Here they are ranged in silence, taking the rock to screen them.

681b

CYCLOPS: On which side?

682

CHORUS: On thy right.

682b

CYCLOPS: Where?

682c

CHORUS: Close against the rock. Hast caught them?

683b

CYCLOPS: Trouble on trouble! I have run my skull against the rock and cracked it.

684b

CHORUS: Aye, and they are escaping thee.

685

CYCLOPS: This way, was it not? 'Twas this way thou saidst.

685b

CHORUS: No, not this way.

686

CYCLOPS: Which then?

686b

CHORUS: They are getting round thee on the left.

687

CYCLOPS: Alas! I am being mocked; ye jeer me in my evil plight.

688

CHORUS: They are no longer there; but facing thee that stranger stands.

689

CYCLOPS: Master of villainy, where, oh! where art thou?

689b

ODYSSEUS: Some way from thee I am keeping careful guard over the person of Odysseus.

691

CYCLOPS: What, a new name! hast changed thine?

692

ODYSSEUS: Yes, Odysseus the name my father gave me. But thou wert doomed to pay for thy unholy feast; for I should have seen Troy burned to but sorry purpose, unless I had avenged on thee the slaughter of my comrades.

696

CYCLOPS: Woe is me! 'tis an old oracle coming true; yes, it said I should have my eye put out by thee on thy way home from Troy; but it

likewise foretold that thou wouldst surely pay for this, tossing on the sea for many a day.

701

ODYSSEUS: Go hang! E'en as I say, so have I done. And now will I get me to the beach and start my hollow ship across the sea of Sicily to the land of my fathers.

704

CYCLOPS: Thou shalt not; I will break a boulder off this rock and crush thee, crew and all, beneath my throw. Blind though I be, I will climb the hill, mounting through yonder tunnel.

708

CHORUS: As for us, henceforth will we be the servants of Bacchus, sharing the voyage of this hero Odysseus.

Notes

¹ It is difficult to make anything of the Greek as it stands; and Hermann is probably right in his suspicion that something has been lost after l. 265. In the absence of any emendation that commends itself an attempt has been made to follow the received text.

² According to Hermann, whose explanation is here followed, ll. 362-3 are spoken ironically, "pray do not consider my feelings; go on with your feast, as long as I am not asked to join it."

³ This line is clearly out of place as it stands; it has been proposed to place it either after line 385 or 395, after either of which it would be appropriate.

⁴ i.e., to catch the blood as the axe strikes, but the expression is a curious one. Kirchhoff gives γνάθους, in apposition to σφαγεία, taking this apparently to mean "slaughtering tools."

⁵ Perhaps οὐκ ἔχοντε καταφυγεῖν might be read, to give some meaning to these worthless lines; but, as Paley points out, there are so many reasons for deciding them to be spurious that it is scarcely worth examining them very closely.

⁶ Herwerden's ἦδει seems preferable to ἦβη which is probably corrupt.

⁷ Hermann supplies the lacuna before φιλεῖ with φίλος ὤν, but there is so much corruption in this and the following few lines that little reliance can be placed on any emendation, nor is the sense very clear.

⁸ Paley agrees with Kirchhoff in thinking a line has been lost here.

⁹ καταλάβῃ, but one MS. has καταβάλῃ “upset,” which Kirchhoff prefers.

¹⁰ Paley supposes a line to have been lost here in which the Cyclops asked “And how must I drink this?”

¹¹ σιγῶντα, but many editors follow Casaubon in reading δὲ σπῶντα “drink it off.”

¹² ἐν τῷ Καρὶ κινδυνεύειν “to run a risk in the person of the Carian.” Latin *experimentum facere in corpore vili*, i.e. to let some one, whose life is less valuable, run the risk instead of doing so oneself. The Carians, being the earliest mercenaries, were commonly selected for any very dangerous enterprise and so this proverb arose.

¹³ i.e., “as blind as you must be if you cannot see it;” but Paley interprets “as you say” but not as is really the case.